

From Potentials and Chemicals to the Mind

The Neurological and Psychological Foundations of the Mind

Jack Wetherell

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1 Nervous System Structure

The nervous system is a highly organized and complex network responsible for coordinating the body's activities, processing sensory information, and enabling cognition, movement, and homeostasis. It is broadly divided into two main components:

- **Central Nervous System (CNS):** Comprises the brain and spinal cord. It is responsible for integrating information and generating responses.
- **Peripheral Nervous System (PNS):** Consists of nerves outside the CNS and connects the CNS to the rest of the body.

This section focuses on the major anatomical structures of the nervous system and their functions.

1.1 The Cerebrum

The cerebrum is the largest part of the brain and is responsible for higher cognitive functions such as thinking, reasoning, memory, and voluntary movement.

It is divided into two hemispheres (left and right), connected by the corpus callosum, which allows communication between them. Each hemisphere is further divided into four lobes:

- **Frontal lobe:** Involved in decision-making, planning, personality, and voluntary motor control.
- **Parietal lobe:** Processes sensory information such as touch, temperature, and pain.
- **Temporal lobe:** Important for hearing, language comprehension, and memory.
- **Occipital lobe:** Responsible for visual processing.

The outer layer of the cerebrum, known as the **cerebral cortex**, is highly folded, increasing surface area and allowing for greater cognitive capacity.

1.2 The Cerebellum

The cerebellum is located beneath the cerebrum and plays a crucial role in coordinating movement, balance, and posture.

Although it does not initiate movement, it fine-tunes motor activity by comparing intended movement with actual performance. This allows for smooth, precise, and coordinated actions.

Damage to the cerebellum can result in:

- Ataxia (loss of coordination)
- Tremors
- Difficulty maintaining balance

1.3 The Midbrain and Brainstem

The brainstem connects the brain to the spinal cord and is essential for basic life functions.

It is divided into three parts:

- **Midbrain:** Involved in visual and auditory reflexes and motor control.
- **Pons:** Acts as a relay station between different parts of the brain and is involved in sleep and respiration.

- **Medulla oblongata:** Regulates vital autonomic functions such as heart rate, breathing, and blood pressure.

The brainstem is critical for survival, as it controls involuntary processes necessary for life.

1.4 Cranial Nerves

Cranial nerves are a set of 12 paired nerves that emerge directly from the brain rather than the spinal cord.

They are responsible for sensory and motor functions of the head and neck, including:

- Vision (optic nerve)
- Eye movement (oculomotor, trochlear, abducens nerves)
- Facial sensation and expression (trigeminal and facial nerves)
- Hearing and balance (vestibulocochlear nerve)
- Swallowing and speech (glossopharyngeal and vagus nerves)

Each cranial nerve has a specific function and can be tested clinically to assess neurological function.

1.5 Ventricles

The ventricles are interconnected cavities within the brain filled with cerebrospinal fluid (CSF).

There are four ventricles:

- Two lateral ventricles
- Third ventricle
- Fourth ventricle

CSF serves several important functions:

- Cushions and protects the brain
- Maintains chemical stability
- Removes waste products

CSF is produced by the choroid plexus and circulates through the ventricles and around the brain and spinal cord.

1.6 Spinal Cord

The spinal cord is a long, cylindrical structure that extends from the brainstem down the vertebral column.

It serves two main functions:

- **Transmission:** Carries sensory information to the brain and motor commands from the brain to the body.
- **Reflexes:** Mediates rapid, automatic responses to stimuli without requiring conscious input from the brain.

The spinal cord is segmented, with each segment giving rise to a pair of spinal nerves.

1.7 Peripheral Nerves

Peripheral nerves are part of the PNS and connect the CNS to muscles, glands, and sensory organs.

They are classified into:

- **Sensory (afferent) nerves:** Carry information from the body to the CNS.
- **Motor (efferent) nerves:** Carry commands from the CNS to muscles and glands.

The PNS can also be divided into:

- **Somatic nervous system:** Controls voluntary movements.
- **Autonomic nervous system:** Regulates involuntary functions such as heart rate and digestion.

The autonomic nervous system is further subdivided into:

- **Sympathetic division:** Prepares the body for “fight or flight” responses.
- **Parasympathetic division:** Promotes “rest and digest” functions.

1.8 Summary

The nervous system is a hierarchical and integrated system in which different structures work together to process information and coordinate responses. The brain handles complex processing, the spinal cord relays and integrates signals, and peripheral nerves connect the entire system to the body.

Understanding these structural components provides the foundation for studying neuronal function, signaling, and neurological disorders.

2 Neuron Structure

Neurons are the fundamental functional units of the nervous system. They are specialized cells designed to transmit electrical and chemical signals over long distances, enabling communication within the body. Unlike most other cell types, neurons are highly polarized, meaning their structure is asymmetrical and optimized for directional signaling.

A typical neuron consists of three main regions: the soma (cell body), dendrites, and the axon. In addition, neurons contain specialized intracellular structures that support their high metabolic and signaling demands.

2.1 Soma, Dendrites, and the Axon

2.1.1 Soma (Cell Body)

The soma is the central part of the neuron and contains the nucleus and most of the cell's organelles. It serves as the metabolic and synthetic center of the neuron.

Key functions of the soma include:

- Integration of incoming signals from dendrites
- Synthesis of proteins and neurotransmitters
- Maintenance of cellular health and homeostasis

The soma plays a critical role in determining whether a neuron will generate an action potential, based on the inputs it receives.

2.1.2 Dendrites

Dendrites are branching extensions that arise from the soma. They are the primary sites for receiving synaptic input from other neurons.

Key features of dendrites:

- Highly branched to increase surface area
- Contain dendritic spines, which are small protrusions where synapses form
- Specialized for receiving chemical signals and converting them into electrical signals (graded potentials)

The structure of dendrites allows neurons to receive input from thousands of other neurons simultaneously.

2.1.3 Axon

The axon is a long, thin projection that carries electrical signals away from the soma toward other neurons or target cells (e.g., muscle or gland cells).

Important regions of the axon include:

- **Axon hillock:** The region where the axon emerges from the soma; this is where action potentials are typically initiated.
- **Axon shaft:** Conducts the action potential along its length.
- **Axon terminals (synaptic boutons):** The distal ends where neurotransmitters are released.

Some axons are covered in myelin, a fatty insulating layer that increases the speed of signal transmission.

2.2 The Nucleus, Rough Endoplasmic Reticulum (RER), and Golgi Apparatus

Neurons have high metabolic demands and require efficient systems for protein synthesis and transport.

2.2.1 Nucleus

The nucleus contains the cell's genetic material (DNA) and controls gene expression. It regulates the production of proteins necessary for neuronal function, including receptors, ion channels, and structural proteins.

2.2.2 Rough Endoplasmic Reticulum (RER)

In neurons, the RER is highly developed and is referred to as **Nissl substance**. It is responsible for synthesizing proteins, particularly those destined for membranes or secretion.

Functions include:

- Production of neurotransmitter-related proteins
- Synthesis of ion channels and receptors

2.2.3 Golgi Apparatus

The Golgi apparatus modifies, sorts, and packages proteins produced by the RER.

Its roles include:

- Post-translational modification of proteins
- Packaging proteins into vesicles
- Directing proteins to their appropriate cellular destinations

This system ensures that proteins are correctly processed and delivered where needed within the neuron.

2.3 Microtubules, Kinesin, and Dynein

Neurons rely heavily on intracellular transport due to their length, especially in long axons.

2.3.1 Microtubules

Microtubules are structural components of the cytoskeleton that act as tracks for intracellular transport. They extend throughout the axon and dendrites.

Functions:

- Provide structural support
- Serve as pathways for transporting organelles and vesicles

2.3.2 Kinesin and Dynein

These are motor proteins that move along microtubules, carrying cargo within the neuron.

- **Kinesin:** Moves cargo away from the soma (anterograde transport), toward the axon terminals.
- **Dynein:** Moves cargo toward the soma (retrograde transport).

This bidirectional transport system is essential for:

- Delivering neurotransmitters and proteins to synapses
- Recycling materials from axon terminals
- Maintaining neuronal health

2.4 Vesicles and SNARE Proteins

2.4.1 Synaptic Vesicles

Synaptic vesicles are small membrane-bound structures found in axon terminals. They store neurotransmitters and release them into the synaptic cleft during neuronal communication.

Key steps:

- Vesicles are filled with neurotransmitters
- They move toward the presynaptic membrane
- They fuse with the membrane and release contents via exocytosis

2.4.2 SNARE Proteins

SNARE proteins are a group of proteins that mediate the fusion of vesicles with the presynaptic membrane.

They ensure:

- Precise docking of vesicles
- Rapid and controlled neurotransmitter release

This process is tightly regulated and often triggered by calcium influx during an action potential.

2.5 Neurotransmitters

Neurotransmitters are chemical messengers that transmit signals across synapses from one neuron to another.

They can be broadly classified into:

- **Excitatory neurotransmitters** (e.g., glutamate): Increase the likelihood of an action potential.
- **Inhibitory neurotransmitters** (e.g., GABA): Decrease the likelihood of an action potential.

Other important neurotransmitters include:

- Dopamine (movement, reward)
- Serotonin (mood, sleep)
- Acetylcholine (muscle activation, memory)

Neurotransmitters bind to receptors on the postsynaptic cell, leading to changes in electrical activity.

2.6 Summary

Neuron structure is highly specialized to support rapid and efficient communication. The soma integrates signals, dendrites receive input, and the axon transmits output. Intracellular systems such as the RER, Golgi apparatus, and cytoskeleton ensure that proteins and materials are produced and transported effectively. Vesicles and neurotransmitters enable communication between neurons, forming the basis of all nervous system function.

Understanding neuronal structure is essential for studying how neurons generate and transmit signals, which is explored in the next section on neuron firing.

3 Neuron Firing

Neuron firing refers to the process by which neurons generate and transmit electrical signals. This involves changes in the membrane potential due to the movement of ions across the neuronal membrane. These electrical signals allow neurons to communicate rapidly and efficiently.

3.1 Resting Membrane Potential

The resting membrane potential is the electrical potential difference across the membrane of a neuron when it is not actively firing. It is typically around:

$$V_m \approx -70 \text{ mV}$$

This negative potential arises due to:

- Unequal distribution of ions (Na^+ , K^+ , Cl^-)
- Selective permeability of the membrane (more permeable to K^+)
- The activity of the Na^+/K^+ ATPase pump (3 Na^+ out, 2 K^+ in)

3.1.1 Nernst Equation

The equilibrium potential for a single ion can be calculated using the Nernst equation:

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At body temperature (37°C), this simplifies to:

$$E_{ion} \approx \frac{61}{z} \log \left(\frac{[ion]_{out}}{[ion]_{in}} \right) \text{ mV}$$

3.1.2 Typical Ion Equilibrium Potentials

- Potassium (K^+): $\approx -90 \text{ mV}$
- Sodium (Na^+): $\approx +60 \text{ mV}$
- Chloride (Cl^-): $\approx -65 \text{ mV}$

The resting membrane potential is closest to the potassium equilibrium potential because the membrane is most permeable to K^+ at rest.

3.2 Graded Potentials

Graded potentials are small changes in membrane potential that occur in dendrites and the soma.

Characteristics:

- Can be depolarizing (less negative) or hyperpolarizing (more negative)
- Decrease in strength with distance (not all-or-none)
- Summate spatially and temporally

Examples:

- Excitatory postsynaptic potentials (EPSPs): move membrane toward threshold
- Inhibitory postsynaptic potentials (IPSPs): move membrane away from threshold

3.3 Action Potentials

An action potential is a rapid, all-or-none electrical signal that travels along the axon.

3.3.1 Threshold

If the membrane potential reaches approximately:

$$-55 \text{ mV}$$

voltage-gated Na^+ channels open, initiating the action potential.

3.3.2 Phases of the Action Potential

1. Resting State ($\approx -70 \text{ mV}$)

- Voltage-gated channels closed
- Leak channels maintain resting potential

2. Depolarization (up to $\approx +30 \text{ mV}$)

- Rapid opening of voltage-gated Na^+ channels
- Na^+ influx drives membrane potential toward E_{Na} ($\approx +60 \text{ mV}$)

3. Repolarization

- Na^+ channels inactivate
- Voltage-gated K^+ channels open
- K^+ exits the cell

4. Hyperpolarization (≈ -80 to -90 mV)

- Continued K^+ efflux
- Membrane approaches E_K

5. Return to Rest

- K^+ channels close
- Na^+/K^+ pump restores ion gradients

3.4 Neurotransmitter Release

When an action potential reaches the axon terminal:

- Voltage-gated Ca^{2+} channels open
- Ca^{2+} enters the terminal
- This triggers vesicle fusion via SNARE proteins
- Neurotransmitters are released into the synaptic cleft

The amount of neurotransmitter released is proportional to calcium influx.

3.5 Reuptake

After release, neurotransmitters must be cleared from the synapse to terminate the signal.

Mechanisms include:

- **Reuptake:** Transport back into the presynaptic neuron
- **Enzymatic degradation:** e.g., acetylcholine broken down by acetylcholinesterase
- **Diffusion:** Away from the synaptic cleft

Reuptake is a key target for many drugs (e.g., SSRIs for serotonin).

3.6 Refractory Periods

After an action potential, the neuron enters a refractory period:

3.6.1 Absolute Refractory Period

- No new action potential can be generated
- Due to inactivation of Na^+ channels

3.6.2 Relative Refractory Period

- A stronger-than-normal stimulus is required
- Occurs during hyperpolarization

These periods ensure:

- Unidirectional propagation of action potentials
- Controlled firing frequency

3.7 Summary

Neuron firing is a tightly regulated process involving ion movement across the membrane. The resting membrane potential is primarily determined by potassium permeability, while action potentials arise from rapid changes in sodium and potassium conductance. The Nernst equation provides a quantitative understanding of ion equilibrium potentials, which underpin neuronal excitability. Neurotransmitter release and reuptake enable communication between neurons, while refractory periods ensure proper signal timing and direction.

4 Glial Cells

Glial cells, or *neuroglia*, are the non-neuronal cells of the nervous system. Although neurons are the cells primarily responsible for generating and transmitting electrical signals, glial cells are essential for maintaining the environment in which neurons can function. They provide structural support, metabolic support, immune defense, insulation, waste clearance, and regulation of the extracellular environment.

For many years, glial cells were thought to play only a passive supporting role. It is now clear that they are active participants in nervous system function. They influence synaptic transmission, help shape neural development, maintain homeostasis, and respond to injury and disease. In many neurological disorders, glial dysfunction is a major component of the pathology.

Glial cells are found in both the central nervous system (CNS) and the peripheral nervous system (PNS). Different types of glial cells are specialized for different roles depending on their location.

The major glial cell types considered in this section are:

- Astrocytes
- Satellite cells
- Oligodendrocytes
- Schwann cells
- Ependymal cells
- Microglia

A major functional theme in glial biology is that neurons cannot function properly in isolation. Every neuron depends on glial cells to regulate ions, recycle neurotransmitters, provide energy substrates, insulate axons, and protect nervous tissue from damage.

4.1 Astrocytes and Satellite Cells

4.1.1 Astrocytes

Astrocytes are star-shaped glial cells found in the CNS. Their name comes from their characteristic branched appearance (*astro* meaning “star”). They are among the most abundant glial cells in the brain and spinal cord and perform a wide range of supportive and regulatory functions.

Astrocytes have many long processes that extend outward and make contact with neurons, synapses, blood vessels, and the pial surface of the brain. Because of this extensive connectivity, astrocytes are ideally positioned to coordinate communication between neurons and the surrounding environment.

The major functions of astrocytes include:

1. Structural support Astrocytes help maintain the physical architecture of nervous tissue. Their processes occupy the spaces between neurons and contribute to the organized arrangement of cells in the CNS.

2. Regulation of the extracellular ionic environment Neuronal activity causes ions, especially potassium (K^+), to move across membranes. When neurons fire repeatedly, extracellular potassium can rise. If this is not controlled, nearby neurons can become abnormally depolarized and excessively excitable.

Astrocytes help buffer extracellular K^+ by taking it up and redistributing it. This process is often referred to as *spatial buffering*. It is essential for maintaining stable membrane potentials and preventing uncontrolled excitation.

3. Neurotransmitter uptake and recycling After neurotransmitters are released into the synaptic cleft, they must be removed efficiently. Astrocytes are especially important in the uptake of glutamate and GABA from the extracellular space.

For example:

- Astrocytes remove glutamate from synapses using excitatory amino acid transporters.
- Within astrocytes, glutamate can be converted to glutamine.

- Glutamine is then transported back to neurons, where it is used to synthesize glutamate again.

This is known as the **glutamate-glutamine cycle**. It prevents excitotoxicity and allows continued synaptic transmission.

4. Metabolic support for neurons Neurons have extremely high energy demands and limited capacity for energy storage. Astrocytes help support neurons metabolically by storing glycogen and supplying energy substrates such as lactate.

This metabolic relationship is sometimes described as the *astrocyte-neuron lactate shuttle*. Astrocytes can take up glucose from blood vessels, process it, and provide intermediates that neurons can use for ATP production.

5. Contribution to the blood-brain barrier The blood-brain barrier (BBB) is a highly selective barrier that separates circulating blood from the brain extracellular fluid. It protects the CNS from toxins, pathogens, and fluctuations in blood composition.

The BBB is formed primarily by:

- Tight junctions between endothelial cells of CNS capillaries
- A basement membrane
- Astrocytic end-feet surrounding the vessels

Astrocytes do not create the tight junctions themselves, but they play an important role in inducing and maintaining BBB properties in endothelial cells.

6. Modulation of synaptic activity Astrocytes are now understood to be part of the **tripartite synapse**, which includes:

- The presynaptic terminal
- The postsynaptic membrane
- Associated astrocytic processes

Astrocytes can detect neurotransmitter release and respond by altering calcium signaling within themselves. In turn, they may release signaling molecules sometimes called *gliotransmitters*, which can influence nearby neurons and synapses.

Although the exact extent of astrocytic signaling remains an active area of research, it is clear that astrocytes play a more dynamic role in neural communication than previously thought.

7. Response to injury Following CNS injury, astrocytes become reactive. This process is called **astrogliosis** or **reactive gliosis**. Reactive astrocytes:

- Increase in size
- Proliferate
- Change gene expression
- Can contribute to glial scar formation

This response can be both helpful and harmful. It helps isolate damaged tissue and limit inflammation, but excessive scar formation may inhibit axonal regeneration.

4.1.2 Satellite Cells

Satellite cells are glial cells of the PNS. They surround the cell bodies of neurons in peripheral ganglia, such as dorsal root ganglia and autonomic ganglia.

Their functions are similar in some ways to those of astrocytes, but they are more localized around neuronal somata rather than distributed throughout broader tissue.

Major functions of satellite cells include:

- Providing structural support around neuronal cell bodies
- Regulating the chemical microenvironment around ganglion neurons
- Controlling ion concentrations
- Participating in nutrient exchange
- Modulating neuronal excitability

Satellite cells are increasingly recognized as important in pain pathways. Changes in satellite cell function may contribute to chronic pain states by altering the excitability of sensory neurons in ganglia.

4.2 Oligodendrocytes

Oligodendrocytes are myelinating glial cells of the CNS. Their main function is to produce myelin sheaths around CNS axons.

The name comes from Greek roots meaning “cells with few branches,” reflecting their morphology compared with astrocytes. Each oligodendrocyte extends several processes, and each process can wrap around a segment of an axon.

A single oligodendrocyte can myelinate parts of multiple axons. This is an important distinction from Schwann cells in the PNS, which generally myelinate only one internode of one axon.

4.2.1 Functions of oligodendrocytes

1. Myelin production Oligodendrocytes wrap their membrane around axons to form myelin. Myelin is a lipid-rich insulating sheath that reduces current loss across the axonal membrane and greatly increases the speed of action potential conduction.

2. Support of axonal integrity Oligodendrocytes do more than simply insulate axons. They also contribute to long-term axonal health and survival. Disruption of oligodendrocyte function can lead not only to demyelination but also to axonal degeneration.

3. Organization of nodal architecture Myelination helps organize the axonal membrane into distinct functional regions:

- **Internodes:** myelinated segments
- **Nodes of Ranvier:** gaps between myelinated segments

Voltage-gated sodium channels become concentrated at the nodes of Ranvier, allowing action potentials to be regenerated there during saltatory conduction.

4.2.2 Clinical significance

Oligodendrocyte damage is central to several CNS diseases. The most important example is:

Multiple sclerosis is an inflammatory demyelinating disease of the CNS in which immune-mediated damage leads to loss of myelin and impairment of signal conduction. Because myelin is necessary for rapid and reliable transmission, demyelination causes a wide range of neurological symptoms, including:

- Weakness
- Sensory disturbance
- Visual impairment
- Poor coordination
- Fatigue

Remyelination may occur to some degree, but repeated damage can eventually lead to permanent neurological deficits.

4.3 Schwann Cells

Schwann cells are the myelinating glia of the PNS. They perform for peripheral nerves a role analogous to that of oligodendrocytes in the CNS, but with important structural and functional differences.

4.3.1 Myelinating Schwann cells

A myelinating Schwann cell wraps itself repeatedly around a segment of a single axon to form one internode of myelin. Thus:

- One Schwann cell myelinates one segment of one axon
- Multiple Schwann cells are needed along the length of a single axon

As in the CNS, the gaps between myelinated segments are the nodes of Ranvier, where action potentials are regenerated.

4.3.2 Non-myelinating Schwann cells

Not all Schwann cells produce myelin. Some envelop multiple small axons without wrapping them in concentric layers of membrane. These are non-myelinating Schwann cells, and the structures they form are sometimes called *Remak bundles*.

These cells still provide support and protection even though they do not create classic myelin sheaths.

4.3.3 Functions of Schwann cells

1. Myelination in the PNS Schwann cells insulate peripheral axons and increase conduction velocity.

2. Support for axonal regeneration One of the most important differences between the CNS and PNS is the greater regenerative capacity of peripheral nerves. Schwann cells are crucial for this process.

After peripheral nerve injury, Schwann cells:

- Help clear myelin debris
- Proliferate
- Form longitudinal pathways that guide regrowing axons
- Secrete growth-promoting factors

This makes successful axonal regeneration much more likely in the PNS than in the CNS.

3. Maintenance of axonal health Schwann cells also provide trophic and metabolic support to peripheral axons.

4.3.4 Clinical significance

Damage to Schwann cells or peripheral myelin occurs in several neuropathies, including:

- Guillain-Barré syndrome
- Charcot-Marie-Tooth disease
- Diabetic neuropathy

These disorders may lead to slowed nerve conduction, weakness, sensory loss, and reduced reflexes.

4.4 Myelin

Myelin is not itself a separate cell type, but it is so important that it deserves focused discussion.

Myelin is a multilayered, lipid-rich membrane wrapped around axons. Its primary role is to electrically insulate axons and improve the efficiency of action potential conduction.

4.4.1 Composition of myelin

Myelin contains:

- A high proportion of lipids
- Specific structural proteins

Its lipid-rich composition gives white matter its pale appearance. White matter in the CNS consists largely of myelinated axons, whereas grey matter contains more neuronal cell bodies, dendrites, synapses, and unmyelinated structures.

4.4.2 How myelin increases conduction velocity

Myelin increases conduction speed by:

- Increasing membrane resistance
- Decreasing membrane capacitance
- Reducing ion leakage across the membrane

Instead of being regenerated continuously along the entire axon, the action potential is regenerated only at the nodes of Ranvier. The current effectively “jumps” from node to node, a process called **saltatory conduction**.

This makes conduction:

- Much faster
- More energy efficient
- More reliable over long distances

4.4.3 Nodes of Ranvier

Nodes of Ranvier are small gaps between myelinated segments. These regions contain high densities of voltage-gated sodium channels, allowing the action potential to be boosted repeatedly as it travels.

Proper clustering of these channels depends on normal myelin structure and glial support.

4.4.4 Consequences of demyelination

When myelin is damaged:

- Current leaks out of the axon
- Conduction becomes slower
- Action potentials may fail to propagate

This can produce major neurological deficits even if the axon itself is initially intact.

4.5 Ependymal Cells

Ependymal cells are glial cells that line the ventricles of the brain and the central canal of the spinal cord. They form an epithelial-like lining and are involved in the production and circulation of cerebrospinal fluid (CSF).

4.5.1 Location

Ependymal cells are found:

- Along the walls of the cerebral ventricles
- Along the central canal of the spinal cord

A specialized population of ependymal cells, together with capillaries and connective tissue, forms the **choroid plexus**, which produces most of the CSF.

4.5.2 Functions

1. CSF production Within the choroid plexus, modified ependymal cells help secrete CSF. CSF is important for:

- Mechanical cushioning of the CNS
- Buoyancy
- Chemical stability
- Waste removal

2. CSF circulation Many ependymal cells have cilia on their apical surface. The beating of these cilia helps move CSF through the ventricular system.

3. Barrier and exchange functions Although not identical to the blood-brain barrier, ependymal cells contribute to the regulation of exchange between CSF and nervous tissue.

4.5.3 Clinical significance

Abnormalities involving ependymal cells or CSF flow can contribute to **hydrocephalus**, a condition in which CSF accumulates within the ventricular system, increasing intracranial pressure and potentially damaging brain tissue.

4.6 Microglia

Microglia are the resident immune cells of the CNS. Unlike most other glial cells, which arise from neuroectodermal origins, microglia are derived from mesodermal lineage and are related to macrophages.

They constantly survey the CNS environment and act as the primary defense cells of the brain and spinal cord.

4.6.1 Functions of microglia

1. Immune surveillance Microglia extend and retract their processes continuously to monitor the surrounding tissue for signs of infection, injury, or abnormal protein accumulation.

2. Phagocytosis When activated, microglia can engulf and remove:

- Dead cells
- Cellular debris
- Pathogens
- Protein aggregates

3. Inflammatory signaling Microglia release cytokines and other signaling molecules that coordinate inflammatory responses. This can be protective, especially during infection or acute injury, but excessive or chronic inflammation can damage neurons.

4. Synaptic pruning During development, microglia help refine neural circuits by removing unnecessary synapses. This process is important for normal maturation of the nervous system.

There is also evidence that microglia continue to influence synaptic remodeling in the adult brain.

4.6.2 Activation states

In their resting or surveillant state, microglia have highly branched processes and are constantly scanning the local environment. When activated by injury or infection, they become less ramified and more amoeboid in shape, reflecting their phagocytic role.

Microglial activation is not simply “on” or “off”; rather, it exists along a spectrum. Depending on the context, microglia may promote repair or contribute to pathology.

4.6.3 Clinical significance

Microglial dysfunction or chronic activation has been implicated in many neurological diseases, including:

- Alzheimer's disease
- Parkinson's disease
- Multiple sclerosis
- Stroke
- Traumatic brain injury

In these conditions, microglia may contribute both to tissue protection and to secondary damage.

4.7 Comparison of CNS and PNS Glia

It is useful to compare glial organization in the CNS and PNS.

CNS glia

- Astrocytes: homeostasis, BBB support, neurotransmitter uptake, metabolic support
- Oligodendrocytes: myelination of CNS axons
- Ependymal cells: ventricular lining and CSF dynamics
- Microglia: immune surveillance and phagocytosis

PNS glia

- Schwann cells: myelination and axonal support in peripheral nerves
- Satellite cells: support of neuronal cell bodies in ganglia

Although their names and details differ, many of these cells perform analogous roles in their respective systems.

4.8 Functional Importance of Glia in Nervous System Physiology

It is impossible to understand nervous system function fully without understanding glial cells. Their importance can be summarized in several major principles:

- **Neurons require a controlled environment.** Glia maintain ion concentrations, remove excess neurotransmitters, and regulate extracellular composition.
- **Rapid conduction requires insulation.** Oligodendrocytes and Schwann cells create myelin, allowing efficient long-distance signaling.
- **The CNS requires protection.** Astrocytes support the blood-brain barrier, and microglia provide immune surveillance.
- **The nervous system requires maintenance and repair.** Glia respond to injury, remove debris, and in the PNS help guide regeneration.
- **Synaptic function is not purely neuronal.** Astrocytes and microglia both influence synaptic structure and activity.

4.9 Summary

Glial cells are essential partners of neurons. Astrocytes and satellite cells regulate the extracellular environment and provide metabolic and structural support. Oligodendrocytes and Schwann cells produce myelin, allowing rapid conduction of action potentials. Ependymal cells line the ventricular system and contribute to CSF production and circulation. Microglia act as the immune cells of the CNS, clearing debris and responding to injury or infection.

Although neurons are often emphasized because of their electrical activity, glial cells are indispensable for normal nervous system structure and function. Without glia, neurons could not maintain homeostasis, communicate efficiently, or survive long-term. For this reason, glial biology is central not only to normal neurophysiology but also to understanding neurological disease.